

The Sūtra Called the Twelve Eyes

Dvādaśalocana-nāma-sūtra · Toh 359 · Derge Kangyur

མགི་བཅ་གཉིས་པ་ཞེས་བརྒྱུད་མེད།

The Sūtra Called the Twelve Eyes, known in Sanskrit as the Dvādaśalocana-nāma-sūtra and in Tibetan as Mig bcu gnyis pa zhes bya ba'i mdo, is a Buddhist sūtra concerned with the interpretation of celestial omens and the divinatory science traditionally known as the Twelve Eyes. The text is set in Rājagṛha, where King Rūpahṛdaya, troubled by alarming signs in the sky — lightning, falling stars, and meteoric iron — is directed by his brahmin astrologers toward this body of knowledge, prompting him to seek clarification from the Buddha himself. It belongs to the sūtra literature of the Kangyur and was translated into Tibetan by the Indian abbot Ajitaśrībhadrā together with the great translator Śākyaod. It is catalogued as Toh 359 in the Kangyur, where it is classified among the general sūtras.

Translated by the Indian abbot, the monk Ajitaśrībhadrā, and the great translator, the monk Śākyaod.

In the Sanskrit language: Dvādaśalocana-nāma-sūtra. In the Tibetan language: The Sūtra Called the Twelve Eyes. May it be accomplished.

The Blessed One, the Buddha, was dwelling in the Veṇuvana grove in the city of Rājagṛha. At that time lightning appeared, shooting stars fell, and meteoric iron descended from the sky. The king Rūpahṛdaya, together with his retinue, summoned his brahmin astrologers and said to them: "What is the cause, and what are the conditions, for all this agitation in the sky?" The brahmins replied: "Omens such as these arise from the scriptural science called the Twelve Eyes. We are too ashamed to expound it."

Then King Rūpahṛdaya went to where the Blessed One was, paid homage at his feet, and spoke these words: "Blessed One, out of compassion for sentient beings, please teach the scriptural science of omens of the Twelve Eyes." The Blessed One declared: "One who has gone forth into renunciation is not of the sort to teach such worldly scriptural sciences as these, which belong to non-Buddhists."

Then King Rūpahṛdaya again addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, out of compassion for me, please resolve this doubt." The Blessed One then granted permission to explain and related the following account of the original

occasion. He declared:

"Great King, long ago, in a time that has passed, there dwelt near a Himalayan mountain a sage named Bhagava. Once he saw a young tigress wandering by and desire arose in him. He lay with her, and when the season came twelve sons were born. When the children were seven years old, both parents died. For twelve years the children performed the rites of accomplishment directed to Brahmā, offering prayers to fulfill their wishes and hopes. Then Brahmā regarded them with compassion and, together with Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods) and the four great kings with their retinues, descended to Jambudvīpa. Brahmā spoke to those children: 'Children, what do you desire?' The children spoke to Brahmā: 'O God, we are by nature still children, greatly limited in understanding and without discernment of what is good or bad. Please teach us what the omens of the sun, moon, planets, stars, and maṇḍalas are, and what the scriptural science of omens is like.' Then Śakra, lord of the gods, spoke to Brahmā: 'O teacher of the gods, it is fitting that you grant these children their accomplishment.' Then Brahmā spoke to the children: 'Children, listen. I shall teach you what the maṇḍalas of the twenty-eight lunar mansions and all the stars are like, and what the omens of the sun, moon, planets, the falling of meteoric iron, the shaking and trembling of the earth, and the scriptural science of omens are.

'In the last month of winter, on the waxing and the waning fortnights, on the eighth, the fourteenth, and the fifteenth days, if the sunlight appears dim and turns dark as darkness, great obstacles will arise for the noble and learned among humankind.

'On the day of the lunar mansion Aśvinī, if something resembling smoke appears from the sun, and it revolves and disperses, for twelve years rain will not fall.

'On the day of the lunar mansion Bharaṇī, if the sun takes on an appearance like the color of gold, the lands of the surrounding kingdoms will be destroyed and a great famine will arise in the center.

'In the last month of winter, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Kārttikā, if the sun appears especially bright, the border regions will be destroyed and rain will not come to the center.

'On the waxing fortnight of the first month of spring, on the day of the lunar mansion Āgrā, if the sun appears distorted and appears as two suns, disease among humans will arise.'"

Obstructions causing harm will arise for two royal factions. In the middle month of spring, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Puṣya, if the sun becomes dark in appearance and the sky to the west of the sun turns pale, obstructions will arise for a great king. In the last month of spring, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Bharaṇī, if both sun and moon are seized by an eclipse, ministers will come to slay the king. In the first month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Pūrvabhādrapadā, if the sun turns red, great obstructing harms will arise for the king, the ministers, and the surrounding regions of that land. In the middle month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Pūrvāṣāḍhā, if the moon is seized by an eclipse in the sign of the fish, the surrounding regions will be thrown into turmoil, and disease among humans and famine will arise. In the last month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Mūla, if the sun and moon appear cracked and a hailstorm falls, great harm will arise in that land. In the first month of autumn, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Aśvinī, if the sun and moon rise together at the same time, great bloodshed will flow through violent conflict in those surrounding regions. In the middle month of autumn, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Kārttikā, if the moon in the sign of the fish takes on a color resembling fire, the surrounding regions of that land will be devastated by enemy armies. In the first month of winter, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Bharaṇī, if a dark red wind arises and the sun becomes unclear, the surrounding regions will be devastated by enemy hosts. In the last month of winter, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Pūrvaphalgunī, if the earth quakes and a great red wind arises, harm will come to a great king. On the day of the lunar mansion Viśākhā, in the waxing fortnights of the first and middle months of spring, if hail falls, disease of the blood and harm will arise in those surrounding regions. In the last month of spring, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Jyeṣṭhā, if at dawn a star appears shining with greater brightness than the sun, great obstructions will arise in regard to all the planets. In the first month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Pūrvāṣāḍhā, if the earth quakes and the sun becomes unclear, the kings of a thousand will fall into conflict and warfare. Again, in the first month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Pūrvāṣāḍhā, if a great wind arises, water will be scarce and food and grain will become insufficient. In the

middle month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Śravaṇa, if a fierce wind rises and the sky turns dark, great terror will arise in the surrounding borderland regions. In the middle month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Pūrvabhādrapadā, if hail falls and thunder rumbles, disease and famine will arise in those surrounding regions. In the last month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Pūrvabhādrapadā, if a great red wind rises from the north and overturns temples, stūpas, houses, and great trees, a great harm will arise in that land. In the first month of autumn, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Aśvinī, if thunder strikes, or shooting stars fall, or hail comes down, a great conflagration will come to that land. In the first month of winter, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Maghā, if rain falls, all the lands will have an abundance of food. In the last month of winter, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Āgrā, if the sky takes on the color of fire, it is a supremely evil omen, and discomfort and great terror will arise in the land. In the last month of spring, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Bharaṇī, if a great sound comes from the north or the sky turns yellow, all enemies will devastate the land. In the first month of spring, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Svātī, if rain falls without wind rising and a rainbow appears, a great city will be consumed by fire. In the first month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Puṣya, if lightning, hail, and drizzling rain fall together, famine will arise in that land.

In the middle month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Mūla, if heavy rain falls and a rainbow appears, harm will come to the royal lineages.

In the last month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Uttarabhādrapadā, if a sound comes from the earth or a black wind rises, famine will arise in that land.

In the middle month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, if a great sound comes from the directions and the intermediate directions, great strife and turmoil will arise in that region.

In the first month of autumn, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Bharaṇī, if a great sound comes from the sky, harm will come to monastics and ascetics.

In the first month of autumn, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion governed by Indra, if a sound comes from the sky, harm will come to the indolent and to livestock.

In the last month of autumn, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Dhaniṣṭhā, if the sound of music comes from the sky, grasses and crops will be excellent, rain will fall in due season, but at the end an epidemic among humans will arise.

In the first month of winter, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Svātī, if a great sound comes from the sky and the sky is disturbed, great terror will arise in that region.

In the last month of winter, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Jyeṣṭhā, if a violent storm rises and the earth quakes, harm and obstacles will come to śramaṇas and brahmins.

In the first month of spring, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Pūrvabhādrapadā, if the earth quakes by day, within two years an army will come to that region in due course.

In the middle month of spring, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Pūrvāṣāḍhā, if the earth trembles, a minister will slay the king, and great upheaval will arise in that region.

In the middle month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, when the lunar mansion Mūla is ascendant, if the earth quakes at night, harm will come to the lords of the elements.

In the last month of summer, on the waxing fortnight, when the lunar mansion Rohiṇī is ascendant, if the earth quakes at night, a red wind arises, and rain does not fall, grain and food will be deficient and an army will come.

In the middle month of autumn, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Uttarabhādrapadā, if the earth quakes by day, that king will be defeated by foreign enemies, and the region will be struck with terror from robbers.

In the last month of autumn, on the waxing fortnight, on the day of the lunar mansion Kārtikā, if the earth quakes, great cities and houses will be destroyed and famine will arise.

In the first month of winter, on the waxing fortnight, in the evening when the lunar mansions Aśvinī and Uttaraphalgunī are ascendant, if the earth quakes,

harm and obstacles will come to young children and pregnant women.

In the middle month of winter, on the waxing fortnight, if the earth quakes on the day of the lunar mansion Mṛgaśīrā or Pūrvabhādrapadā, harm and obstacles will come to those who travel on foot. If on the day of the mansion governed by Indra, or on the day of Maghā, the sacred image in a temple shakes and moves, or is displaced, that region will quickly be destroyed. If a sacred image in a temple is displaced from its seat, or appears silvery, or falls, that region together with its king will come under the dominion of another kingdom. If a sacred image in a temple is displaced or tears flow from its eyes, the brave and cherished heroes of that region, together with their sons and daughters, will become refugees driven out of the land. If a sacred image in a temple is displaced or shakes and something like smoke comes from the shrine, harm will come to the king of that region. If a great temple or a dwelling place similarly shakes, that city will be seized by a neighboring kingdom or consumed by fire.

If the planet Jupiter appears at the edge of the moon, the king will seize the wealth of the rich and harm them. If the sun and moon turn red, harm will come to the lords of the elements. If the planet Saturn appears above the moon, great terror and obstacles will arise in that region.

When these omens occur and the moon is seized by an eclipse at that time, harm and obstacles will come to great kings.

If the moon appears at the natal lunar mansion of a king, and above the moon the planet with a long tail also appears, the king of that region and the kings of neighboring kingdoms will go to war with one another.

If the planet Saturn is at the lunar mansion Rohiṇī and —

— at the center of the lunar mansion Kārttikā, great harm and obstacles will come to all the people of that kingdom, and one third of the population will perish.

If the planets Venus and the lunar mansions Maghā and Pūrva Phalgunī appear at the center of the moon, harm will come to the crops. If the planets Jupiter, Venus, and Saturn turn red, great terror will arise in that region.

If the planet with a long tail appears above the lunar mansion Puṣyā, within no great time a vast army will advance from all four directions. If the planets Jupiter and the red-colored planet Mars appear above the lunar mansion Śravaṇā, great terror and harm will arise in that region for a period of three

years. If the planets Jupiter and Saturn appear above the lunar mansion Viśākhā, many people will die in battle.

If crows perform their dance and hang and huddle atop temples and great buildings, great conflict will arise in that region.

If a woman gives birth to a child of non-human appearance, or if livestock gives birth to a human child, great obstacles and harm will come to the women of that region. If a child in the womb laughs, speaks, or cries, that region will be destroyed. If a woman gives birth to a child with one leg, three legs, or four legs, harm will come to the king of that land. If a child born from a woman's womb is of indeterminate sex, possessing both characteristics, the king of that region will die. If a woman gives birth to an animal or a child with many heads, that region will be destroyed. If a woman gives birth to a child with one head but two faces and three eyes, that region will quickly be destroyed. If a woman gives birth to a child shaped like a pot and having four heads, great terror will arise in that surrounding region. If a woman gives birth to a child with the face of a pig, that region will be destroyed from all four directions. If a woman gives birth to a child whose face blazes like the light of the sun, that region will be destroyed by civil strife. If a small child speaks as though it were a great elder, that surrounding region will be destroyed. If a child emerges from the womb without the mother having been aware of it, great obstacles and harm will arise in that region. If a child resembling a pig or a snake emerges from a woman's womb, that region will be ruined and gripped by great terror through the assaults of demons, obstructing spirits, and disease.

If a woman gives birth to a child that is born already dead, or born with teeth, that region will become desolate and all its people will depart to other directions. If a woman gives birth to a child that has no head and only one arm, great harm will come to that region.

If flowers and fruit appear twice in a region, and if sap drips from trees and fruits, obstacles and harm will come to the king's regent. If at an unseasonable time fruit trees flower and bear fruit, the king together with the people of that land will abandon the region. If the fruit of a fruit tree becomes remarkably fine in color, or if a substance resembling blood drips from it, great terror, disease, and famine will arise in that region. If the shadow of a shade tree does not fall all around but stands only to one side, an enemy army of great power will destroy that part of the land. If a shade tree appears as though it is moving, great terror will arise in that surrounding region. If a shade tree

appears especially brilliant and radiant, the king of that region will be short-lived.

If, when a worldly deity is being propitiated, the deity speaks or smiles, obstacles and harm will come to the king. If a rain of flowers falls, or a red wind arises and insects fall from the sky, that region will be destroyed by bandits. If smoke arises in a worldly deity's temple without any fire having been lit, and the deity also displays signs and miraculous powers, obstacles and harm will come to the king.

If, in a worldly deity's temple, an appearance like that of a lamp blazes forth without any lamp having been lit, obstacles and harm will come to the king's great treasury. If the king enters the inner chambers of his queen and desire does not arise in him, the royal palace will be consumed by fire and various non-virtuous things will befall the king.

If rain and hail fall and brilliant colors appear in the sky, great terror will arise in that surrounding region. If the city is encircled by a whirlwind and a red wind rises while rain like blood falls, great terror will arise in that surrounding region. If lightning flashes and rain falls while masses of cloud break apart into rings and rings, and between those ring-like breaks in the clouds there appears something resembling a city of gandharvas (celestial musicians), great terror will arise in that surrounding region.

If the moon turns red, the cities of that region will be consumed by fire and its people will be decimated by plague. If the moon's rim becomes red while its center turns black, great terror will arise in that region. If the color of the moon appears reddish, like rust, and then suddenly reverts to its natural white, rain will fall heavily without wind rising. If springs appear where a mountain was dry, the harvest will be excellent. If smoke arises in that region without any fire having been lit, great terror will arise in that region. If fire or smoke appears around a bow and arrow rack, the fear of enemies will arise in that region.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, King Rūpasāraprabha together with his retinue rejoiced and gave great praise to what the Blessed One had taught.

This concludes the sūtra called "The Twelfth Eye."

Translator's Notes

- The title "Dvādaśalocana" (Sanskrit) literally means "Twelve Eyes," consistent with the Tibetan rendering. The sūtra is a relatively rare canonical text dealing with astral omens; it is framed as a Buddha-sūtra but its content is worldly prognostication, which explains the Blessed One's initial reluctance. The name "Bhagava" for the sage is likely a Tibetan transcription of Sanskrit Bhṛgu or a similar name; "Bhagava" is also a general honorific, but here it functions as a proper name. The lunar mansion "Āgrā" (Tibetan: འགྲ་) does not correspond to a standard Sanskrit nakṣatra name; it may be a transcription of Mṛgaśīrṣa or another mansion, and the identification is uncertain.

- The phrase rendered as "the moon in the sign of the fish" reflects a recurring idiom in this text where the moon's position in a particular asterism or zodiacal sign is described figuratively; "the sign of the fish" likely refers to Pisces or an asterism in that region, and the same rendering has been used consistently with the preceding passage. The term rendered as "disease of the blood" for རྩི་མུ་མུ་ is a relatively transparent compound meaning ailments associated with blood, possibly epidemic hemorrhagic disease. The phrase འགྲ་མུ་མུ་མུ་མུ་མུ་མུ་ is rendered as "a great conflagration will come to that land," where འགྲ་མུ་ can mean a cooking fire or conflagration; given the context of destructive portents, "conflagration" is the most appropriate sense.

- The phrase rendered "the day of the lunar mansion governed by Indra" corresponds to the mansion Jyeṣṭhā, whose presiding deity is Indra; the text here uses "Indra's day" as a synonym for Jyeṣṭhā, consistent with standard Indian astrological convention. This is the same mansion named explicitly elsewhere in the passage as Jyeṣṭhā, so no inconsistency arises.

The phrase "planet with a long tail" renders the Tibetan term for a comet or the planet with a trailing apparition; in context it most likely refers to a comet as a bad omen, though some traditional readings apply it to particular planetary conjunctions.

The final sentence is incomplete in the source text as given, breaking off mid-passage.

- The passage lists several planetary and teratological omens drawn from a genre of Indian astral and portent literature closely parallel to Sanskrit nimitta-śāstra material. The lunar mansion names Kārttikā, Maghā, Pūrva Phalgunī, Puṣyā, Śravaṇā, and Viśākhā are transliterated directly from the Tibetan phonetic renderings of the Sanskrit nakṣatra names and are kept as such. The phrase rendered "the red-colored planet Mars" represents the Tibetan mig dmar, literally "red-eye," a standard Tibetan epithet for Mars, consistent with the preceding passage's usage. The term rendered "child of indeterminate sex, possessing both characteristics" translates bu ma ning mtshan gnyis pa, literally "a child that is a hermaphrodite with two characteristics," a recognized category in classical Indian omens literature.

- The term rendered "great treasury" for རྩི་མུ་མུ་ is somewhat uncertain; it can also mean "great favor" or "great grant," referring to the king's largesse or authority in dispensing patronage. The interpretation as "treasury" or "royal domain of bounty" best fits the political omen context here.

The city name རྩི་མུ་མུ་མུ་མུ་ (Rūpasāraprabha) is taken as a proper royal name or epithet for the king; the Tibetan is literally "essence of form" or "heart of form," likely rendering a Sanskrit name such as Rūpasāra.

The closing title "The Twelfth Eye" reflects the Tibetan འགྲ་མུ་མུ་མུ་མུ་མུ་མུ་, literally "the twelfth eye," likely indicating this sūtra is the twelfth in a series of texts arranged under the metaphor of "eyes" or visionary omens.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.